

Cover letter draft

Dear Editors,

Please consider our Analysis manuscript, “Pricing Apparent Environmental Performance: Strategic Selection and Reputation under a Zero-Effect Rainfall Null,” for publication in *Ecological Economics*.

The paper studies an ecological-economic system in which environmental scarcity drives demand, providers strategically select requests, observers attribute natural rainfall to accepted events, and valuation and reputation respond—even though the intervention has exactly zero causal effect on rainfall. Using archived ERA5 rainfall at 8 contrasting locations and 60,000 principal Monte Carlo replications, we distinguish natural hazard, apparent efficacy, scenario willingness to pay, transfers, causal rainfall value, and separate social utility.

Espín-Sánchez, Gil-Guirado, and Ryan establish the timing, hazard, persuasion, and historical rain-prayer foundation. Our qualified extension separates requests from provider acceptance, models provider-specific reputation stocks and simulated prices, and reports the unfavorable principal result rather than tuning it away: reputation price premia coexist with negative mean contemporaneous price–success differences. The manuscript addresses the journal's interest in ecological uncertainty, valuation, behavior, institutions, information asymmetry, and plural values.

[AUTHOR CONFIRMATION REQUIRED: The manuscript is original and is not under consideration elsewhere.] It uses no human participants or confidential data. All redistributable analytical inputs, code, acquisition records, checksums, simulation outputs, and manuscript values accompany the submission; exact retrieval records are supplied for audit sources that are not redistributed.

[AUTHOR INPUT REQUIRED: corresponding author name, affiliation, contact details, funding, competing interests, acknowledgements, and any suggested reviewers.]

Sincerely,

[AUTHOR INPUT REQUIRED]